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THE BIG PICTURE OF MODERN COMPUTING

How one human request can move through networks, data centers, AI models, agents and tools.

SCAN FOR THE INTERACTIVE MAP

01 HUMAN

Has a goal: ask a question, search, book or buy.

Start with intent, not technology.

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02 DEVICE

A phone or laptop turns actions into digital messages.

App · keyboard · network connection

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03 INTERNET

Routers move data between networks.

Delay, routing and encryption matter.

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04 APPLICATION

A service authenticates users and processes requests.

API = Application Programming Interface.

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05 DATA CENTER

Servers, storage and networks provide compute capacity.

Power, cooling, availability and cost.

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06 AI MODEL

When needed, a model computes a response from its inputs.

AI = Artificial Intelligence; it may be wrong.

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07 AI AGENT

An agent can plan steps and decide to call tools.

Permissions, checks and stop rules matter.

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08 TOOLS

Software services can search, calculate or change data.

A tool call may affect real systems.

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09 REAL WORLD

A result reaches people or changes external state.

Verify the outcome, not just the text.

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THREE CONTROLS CROSS THE WHOLE SYSTEM

SECURITY Who is allowed?

RELIABILITY What if it fails?

ECONOMICS Is the result worth its cost?

Conceptual route, not a mandatory sequence. Many requests never use AI; models and agents may be arranged differently.

Vlad Belciug · LEARN · free for individual study · original educational schematic · 2026